

I contacted Liquid Web for technical support, I submitted a ticket and my expectation profile formed ... I speculated it'd be a day or two before I heard back. I was wrong. Within ten minutes, Liquid Web Support responded and fixed my issue within 20 minutes. They provided customer service that s-u-c-s and violated expectations.

The result? I'm a disciple of Liquid Web. When someone asks me, "What hosting do you recommend?" I confidently respond with "Liquid Web." I am an evangelic customer. I pay Liquid Web in two forms of currency: 1) My money and 2) My frequent recommendation of their service. The effective value of this latter currency is priceless because I am now their FREE human resource system selling their product. Imagine the potency when you have not just one raving customer, but 10,000. Will your business grow 2% in one year? Or 200%?

To provide great customer service and explode your business, determine your customers' expectation profile. What are their expectations when they deal with your business? How do they relate to competitors and similar businesses in your industry? Make a subjective call on how your customers expect service. Then VIOLATE IT.

Any time you violate your customer's expectations to the positive, you get a dual benefit. First, they buy from you again. Second, raving customers become liaisons and disciples for your business and unpaid human resource systems. Both build speed. Speed builds wealth.

Great customer service costs more to provide, but the benefits should outweigh the costs. If more money were spent on pleasing existing clients rather than trying to find new ones, the average business would survive longer than five years. Unfortunately, business owners who seek money first and needs last often spend their advertising wad on the pursuit of new customers who aren't familiar with their uninspired and sucky customer service. It becomes a constant battle, like emptying a leaky boat with a bucket: Replace the old disgruntled customers with newer, oblivious ones. Violate customer's expectations. Create evangelists. Create human resource systems that will work for you, for free. Attract money.

WHERE ARE YOUR LOYALTIES?

The greatest myth of business ownership is "be your own boss." Owners who live by that mantra eventually find themselves bosses of nothing—dead, bankrupted businesses. Success in business comes from making your customer the boss and the No. 1 stakeholder to your business.

A stakeholder is defined as "Person, group, or organization that has direct or indirect stake in an organization because it can affect or be affected by the organization's actions, objectives, and policies." Long-term business suicide occurs when you are your own selfish stakeholder and forsake your customer. Want to really know why customer service sucks? It's because business owners place their